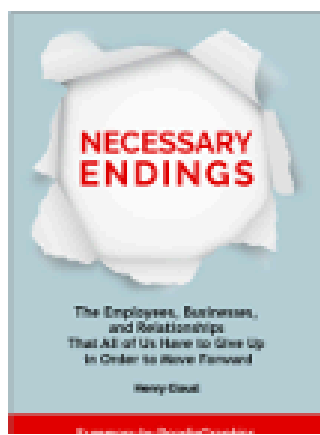




NECESSARY ENDINGS

The Employees, Businesses, and Relationships
That All of Us Have to Give Up
in Order to Move Forward

DR. HENRY CLOUD



The Big “So What”

Often, we must end something before we can begin something else. Yet, it's hard to know when an ending is necessary, and it's even harder to execute it. In this book, Dr. Henry Cloud explains why endings are so difficult, and presents specific strategies and tools to help us move on at the right time.



Introduction



Endings—such as a loved one's death, a divorce, or being laid off—are an inevitable part of life. When we avoid endings or handle them badly, we get stuck in problematic situations, miss out on opportunities, and repeat the same mistakes.



Often, we must end something bad before we can start something good. We may have to “kill” something that we created, or give up something we used to cherish (e.g. ending a toxic relationship or shutting down a failed project/business) to move on to something better.

- There's a season for everything: living and dying, building and deconstructing, mourning and celebrating, etc. We have to end infancy to start toddlerhood, and leave an old job to move to a new one. Likewise, businesses must let go of old products, strategies and business models to stay relevant.
- In this book, Dr. Cloud explains how you can proactively navigate endings to move toward your goals, and to bring relief, hope, and growth.

KEY QUOTES

“Today may be the enemy of your tomorrow.”

“When we fail to end things well, we are destined to repeat the mistakes that keep us from moving on.”

“Good cannot begin until bad ends.”

“Often, in necessary endings, you have to give something up or be willing to lose something in order to gain it.”



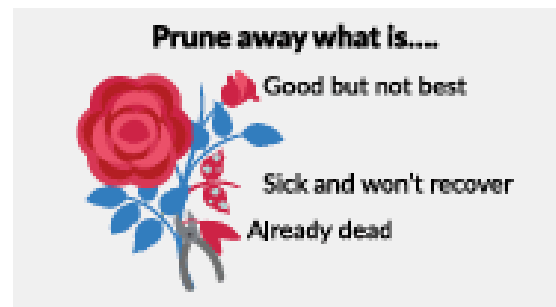
What are Necessary Endings and Why They Matter



All living things need energy to grow, and we have limited fuel to sustain that growth. To thrive and reach your full potential, you must channel your finite time, money, energy, and talents toward a specific vision. If you spread your resources too thinly, you'll dilute your focus and results.



To grow and thrive, we need 3 types of necessary endings. It's like how a gardener tends to a rosebush by pruning away 3 things:



- What is good, but not the best: All plants, such as rosebushes, generate more branches and buds than they can fully support. Gardeners remove the sub-optimal buds/branches to free up resources for the best roses to reach their full potential. Likewise, people and businesses take on more than we can handle sustainably, so we must prune away the less essential items.
- What is sick and won't recover: Sometimes, no amount of effort and resources can heal a sick branch. Gardeners prune away such branches to free up resources for the healthy ones. In our life and business, we get stuck with certain issues when we keep doing the same thing and expecting a different outcome. Learn to let go of the old in order to embrace the new.
- What is already dead: Dead buds/branches occupy space and block the healthy branches from reaching their full height and length. Likewise, we need to remove the stuff that take up dead space in our lives.



Despite their necessity, endings make us uncomfortable because it's human nature to avoid loss, pain and uncertainty. We don't want to confront or hurt others, or we may lack the skills to execute the endings effectively.

- Take a moment to do a "gut check". Examine your beliefs, thoughts and feelings about pruning and endings. What do you feel when you think about ending or pruning away something? Do you encounter any inner discomfort or resistance?

KEY QUOTES

"Are you only achieving average results in relation to where you or your business or team is supposed to be?"

"Both businesses and individuals will begin, gather, and have more activities than they can reasonably sustain."

"To do the same thing over and over again expecting different results is not only crazy, it is a recipe for staying stuck."



Before you start pruning, define the purpose and standards that you're pruning toward.

- Necessary endings should help to achieve your strategic mission or purpose in life. Consciously apply the 3 types of necessary endings—the good, sick, or dead—to all areas of your life, e.g. improving your relationships, business strategies, or project effectiveness.
- Former CEO of General Electric (GE), Jack Welch, is an example of someone who was crystal-clear on what he wanted. His relentless focus drove GE's revenue from \$26bil to \$130bil during his tenure. Welch based his pruning decisions on 4 criteria:
 - (i) GE would only be in businesses where it could be #1 or #2;
 - (ii) Any business that was struggling must be fixed, closed, or sold;
 - (iii) The bottom 10% of the workforce was fired each year; and
 - (iv) All layers of bureaucracy that hindered ideas, communication and productivity were removed.



Moving Forward with Necessary Endings



Normalize Endings

Start by seeing endings as a normal part of life, instead of seeing them as problems. This moves your brain out of fight-or-flight mode and into problem-solution mode.



See things as they really are, not as you wish them to be. Instead of hoping for things to remain unchanged forever or wishing for unlimited time/resources, accept reality so you can deal with it. Normalize endings with 3 organizing principles:

- Embrace life's seasons and cycles. Realize that everything moves in cycles, e.g. day and night, life and death. Match your activities to the life season that you're currently in.

KEY QUOTES

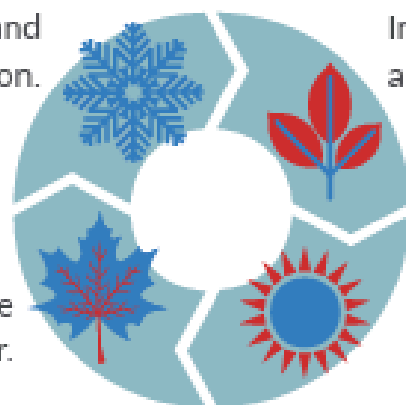
"Pruning is strategic. It is directional and forward-looking."

"Pruning can bring health into the small branches of business or life as well as the big."

"If you see [endings] as normal, expected, and even a good thing, you will embrace them and take action to execute them."

"In business and life, there comes a moment when that reality must be seen and grasped."

In winter, review and regroup for the new season.



In spring, sow the seeds and prepare for growth.

In autumn, harvest the fruits of your labor.

In summer, tend the crops and manage growth.

- (i) In *spring*, prepare the fields/resources, sow the seeds, and lay your foundations for growth. A business may build its network, hire new staff, or secure new clients.
- (ii) In *summer*, tend to the crops, protect them from pests and diseases, and prune the plants as they grow. As a business grows, it must manage its resources and systematize its operations.
- (iii) In *autumn*, harvest the crops before they deteriorate, taking care not to deplete/harm the fields. In business, you must be ready to harvest low-hanging fruits or opportunities.
- (iv) In *winter*, close your accounts, organize your resources, repair your equipment, and review your successes and areas for improvement. Rest, regroup, and prepare for the new season.

Don't sow when you should tend, or tend when you should harvest. It's also unsustainable to stick solely to 1 season (e.g. to only sow or only harvest).

- Accept that there will always be excesses in life. Life generates more life, and every individual or organization will accumulate more things than they can sustain.
 - (i) For example, you'll have more relationships than you can develop fully, more activities than you can sustainably commit to, or more things than you can store. When you juggle too many things, quality naturally drops. Good companies can have too many customers, partners and business activities, and must shut down certain programs or product lines.
 - (ii) You will also have partners, products, or strategies that become outdated or irrelevant over time. Let go of what's no longer essential, so you can focus on what matters.

KEY QUOTES

"Believe in life cycles and seasons. They are real."

"When the numbers are too high, quality suffers."

- Accept the existence of evil and terminal illnesses. You will encounter destructive or incorrigible people who will harm or drain you. Protect yourself and cut them out of your life.



Examine your Internal Maps

Our beliefs and experiences shape how we see the world. Become aware of the mental maps that keep you stuck, so you can change them.



Neuroscience research found that the more we think and behave in a certain way, the more it creates and reinforces certain pathways in our mind. Eventually, we form mental maps which shape how we see the world, think and act.

- Pain is nature's way of telling us that something needs our attention. For example, if you put your finger over a flame, the pain alerts you to remove your finger quickly. However, we can get so used to pain that we assume it's the norm and there's nothing we can do about it. Psychologists call this "learned helplessness".
- When things seem helpless, use this exercise to regain a sense of control, get unstuck, and gradually redesign your mental map:
 - (i) Create 2 columns on a piece of paper. On the left side, write down all the things *beyond* your control e.g. weather, market conditions. Then, on the right side, write down the things you *can* control e.g. reaching out to new contacts, learning a new skill.
 - (ii) You can also brainstorm ideas/options as a team.



Your internal maps come from a mix of your beliefs and past experiences, especially those from your formative years. For example, you may find it harder to leave a dysfunctional relationship if your parents had a similar relationship. Consider if any of these 5 beliefs are holding you back from necessary endings.

- Having an unusually high pain threshold. You get so used to numbing or suppressing your pain that you tolerate issues which can/should be addressed, such as an under-performing employee or an abusive spouse.

KEY QUOTES

"Pain by its nature is a signal that something is wrong, and action is required. So pain should be driving you to do something to end it."

- Covering for others out of a desire to be responsible or nice. You end up shouldering others' responsibilities and thinking that everything depends on you.
- Equating endings with failures. You refuse to be a "quitter" and persevere at all costs—even if it hurts your health and relationships, and there are better ways to use your energy, effort, and resources.
- Feeling mistaken loyalty toward others. You take on others' burdens at your own expense. You keep thinking "I'm doing this to them" instead of thinking "I'm doing this for me".
- Creating an unhealthy dependency by helping people who refuse to take responsibility for their own growth and outcomes.



Get to the Moment of Change

You need some hope to persevere in face of difficulties, but not so much that you live in denial and cling on to something long after it's time to let go. **The "pruning moment" comes when we embrace reality and realize that it's hopeless to keep doing what we're doing.**



Sometimes, such realizations come from past experiences.

- When Julie Shimer became the CEO at Welch Allyn, the company was in a leadership position, and the employees were satisfied with their existing products. However, Shimer's experience with Bel Labs and Motorola had taught her the risks of sticking to a "proven" technology. So, she hired a consultant to thoroughly assess the market and Welch Allyn's position. She concurrently worked with the team to define how they could best serve their clients (doctors and nurses).
- The team envisaged a future where medical staff could enjoy Welch Allyn's solutions with the same experience on any device, much like how Apple's products work seamlessly on a single platform. They quickly realized that the only way to achieve this vision was to phase out the technology they had used for almost 100 years, and to adopt a new integrated platform for all their medical devices.

KEY QUOTES

"Failing well means ending something that is not working and choosing to do something else better."

"Necessary endings happen when you get to a 'good hopelessness'."

"To continue our legacy of being a leading innovator, we had to change to a new and much bigger chapter in Welch Allyn's history."

—Julie Shimer, former CEO of Welch Allyn



If you don't have the experience to know if an ending is necessary, you must rely on diagnostics (below) to gauge if there's real hope for change, or if you're just engaging in wishful thinking.



To identify if you should keep investing time/effort in someone, or if you should initiate an ending, look at their track record.

- Have they consistently performed up to expectations in the past?
- If not, are some of these 9 factors present to suggest that things could change in the future?
 - (i) Participation in *valid change processes*, e.g. rehabilitation or counseling.
 - (ii) New change structures, e.g. scheduled updates to a trainer.
 - (iii) Monitoring systems to track progress/performance.
 - (iv) New skills, experiences, or know-how.
 - (v) A real need to change, with signs that they're taking ownership of the problem and actively looking for solutions.
 - (vi) Self-motivation to sustain the change.
 - (vii) Support from like-minded people (e.g. we're more likely to become overweight if we're surrounded by overweight people, and vice versa).
 - (viii) Help from people with the right skills/experience.
 - (ix) Evidence of success or progress.

Without these factors, you must expect more of the same from that person.



You can also diagnose someone's character. Know which of these 3 types of people you're dealing with, and adapt your strategy to the person/situation accordingly.

- Wise people embrace feedback and adjust their behaviors accordingly, to gain wisdom from their experiences. They

KEY QUOTES

"Nothing mobilizes us like a firm dose of reality...only reality gets us to do difficult things."

"The best predictor of the future, without other variables, is the past."

"It is often irrational to listen to a seemingly good idea from a proven nonperformer."

"We are looking for some sort of movement, instead of ongoing stagnation."

"While hope is a great virtue, hope in unreality is not."

"When truth presents itself, the wise person sees the light, takes it in, and makes adjustments."

genuinely regret it when their actions create a negative impact on others, and seek to improve.

- When dealing with wise people, talk through the issues, discuss possible strategies, and give them resources to solve the problem.
- Foolish people are the opposite. They're unreceptive to feedback, find excuses for their actions, and blame other people or external circumstances. They dismiss their impact on others, refuse to take ownership of the problem, and even see themselves as the victims.
 - When dealing with foolish people, don't bother discussing the problem or giving them resources because they won't listen or change.
 - Instead, set clear limits and consequences. Highlight the lack of change/progress, set limits to minimize the negative impact on others, and let them feel the repercussions of their action/inaction. For example, "Jim, we discussed this issue several times, but there has been no improvement and it has affected the entire team's performance. If this next deadline is not met, I'll be replacing you with someone who can do what's needed."
- Evil people will seek to harm or even destroy you.
 - When dealing with such people, don't try to help or change them. Protect yourself physically, emotional and financially. Distance yourself as much as possible, and preferably limit any communication through lawyers or law enforcement officers.



Don't expect people to change long-standing patterns of behavior unless there's strong evidence of the 9 factors above to suggest otherwise. However, you can facilitate changes by:

- Helping people to operate optimally in their areas of strengths rather than weaknesses. If your colleague or spouse is better at technical details, don't push them to work on creative tasks.
- Bringing in the right wisdom or know-how, e.g. hire consultants or experts who have the skills/experience that you lack.

KEY QUOTES

"The fool tries to adjust the truth so he does not have to adjust to it."

"Whereas you talk to wise people about problems and you talk to fools about consequences, do not talk to evil people at all, period."

- Infusing the right levels of energy and structure to drive the change. This could come in the form of additional manpower, partners, daily reviews, or monthly meetings. It's like having a regular intake of food/nutrients to sustain your body.



Make the Change and Sustain It

Endings are hard. Without deliberate effort, you're likely to avoid them or return to old patterns/habits.



There are several internal barriers which can hold you back from a necessary ending.

- Such barriers include:
 - (i) *Conflicting desires* that keep us from acting decisively. For example, you believe you should end a relationship, but you also believe it's bad to hurt others.
 - (ii) *A hoarder mentality*, which is associated with the fear of losing out. You hold on to things just in case you need them in the future, or cling to outdated ideas/models in hope that things may turn around.
 - (iii) *Putting things off* by telling yourself you'll do it "later", or justifying the status quo by looking selectively at the good aspects while neglecting the bad ones.
- See the full picture—both the good and the bad—so you can deal with the situation more realistically.
- Be clear on your desired outcome, but hold it loosely so you can adapt if circumstances change. Don't cling on to something (e.g. a title or relationship) too tightly, as it may actually increase your risk of losing it.



You're also likely to encounter external barriers to change. This includes people who resist/thwart your efforts because (i) the change doesn't serve their interests, (ii) they feel threatened by your progress, or (iii) it's simply their nature to oppose any idea regardless of whether they have valid reasons.

KEY QUOTES

"Endings, no matter how needed, are hard."

"Incompatible wishes are a formula for resistance."



Create urgency and momentum to initiate and sustain change. Concurrently play up the fear of bad things that will happen if you don't take action, as well as the rewards if you do.

- Imagine the future as vividly as possible, like playing a movie in your mind. If you're frustrated with a colleague's non-performance, imagine speaking with him/her on the same issue 6 months, 1 year, and 2 years from now. Experience the future misery now so you'd feel motivated to act.
- Concurrently hold a clear vision of the future you'd enjoy if you take action today. Regularly see, hear, and feel the details as if you're already living it. Write it down, talk about it, and surround yourself with pictures that remind you of the vision. Get attached to that future so you'll be motivated to stay on the path.
- If the people who must make the changes are too distant from the problem, get them to experience the pain first-hand. For example, get product developers to use their products or observe customers struggling with them.
- Find allies or supporters who will support your goal and push you to move forward. Surround yourself with people who already live the desired end-state. At work, find influencers to spread the new norms. If necessary, bring in external resources (e.g. a coach or accountability partner), or get someone with authority to step in.
- Establish structure in the form of timelines, milestones, action plans, review sessions, resource allocation, and so on.
- Set firm deadlines with specific consequences if the requirements are not met.
- Track your key metrics to monitor if you're making progress.



Equip Yourself for Success

Master the skills and strategies to execute endings effectively.



Use self-selection to achieve your desired outcomes without having to judge or reject people. Set your standards clearly, then let others decide if they're willing to match your standards.

KEY QUOTES

"We need is to make the threat to our future as real in our minds as it is in reality."

"The external structure creates the rails for the train to run on."

KEY QUOTES

- For example, a woman was in a dilemma because she couldn't decide if her boyfriend was the right partner for her. At Dr Cloud's suggestion, she explained the situation honestly to him—that she loved him but couldn't see herself marrying him unless he started to plan ahead and take financial responsibility for their future. By laying out what she wanted, she could stay true to herself and let *him* decide if he was willing to change to be with her.



Ending conversations can be difficult and uncomfortable. Unless you prepare for the conversation, you're likely to side-step the issue.

- Specify your end-goals in advance, e.g. "to express that I care for him", or "to say that I'll call the police if he contacts me again".
- Address conflicting desires. Come to terms with the fact that you can care about someone, yet have to share a painful truth for their own good. Commit to be clear, honest, yet compassionate.
- Prepare the key points or a script. Then, get someone you trust to rehearse the conversation with you and provide feedback.
- Adopt the right tone. People tend to be more receptive when you adopt a soft/caring tone, empathize with them, and validate their feelings.
- Separate the issue from the person. Validate the person and the relationship, while clearly explaining why the issue necessitates an ending.
- Invite the person to repeat what he/she heard, to ensure the message has been clearly understood.
- Once you've truly decided on an ending, do it decisively. Don't leave loose ends to be tied up later. So long as you're clear and kind in your communications, the outcome will usually be positive.
- As a rule of thumb, don't burn bridges except with evil people. In those cases, you should consider having a third party (e.g. a lawyer, HR personnel, or friend) to join you as a witness. Make sure you document the discussion clearly in writing.

"Just as in pulling a tooth, quickly and thoroughly is usually best."

"Don't leave an open door or window if you don't want one. Close it now, so you will not have to do it again."



Internalize the ending so you can move toward your desired vision.

- Embrace the grief rather than avoiding or denying it. This helps you to accept the ending and move on. You can even hold a symbolic “funeral” to create a proper closure.
- Take some time to dissect the experience so you don't repeat the same mistakes or patterns. Ask yourself: (i) what can you learn from the experience, and (ii) what should you consciously let go? It's like how your body metabolizes food by breaking it down into nutrients (that you absorb) and waste (that you discard).



Conclusion and Other Details in the Book



To live to your true potential, you must make the most of where you are right now, *and* do what's necessary to move toward your vision. Start by taking stock of the things that are draining you emotionally, physically, mentally, energetically, spiritually or financially. Then, look for ways to stop and reverse the negative outflow. If that's not possible, then it may be time to plan an ending.



This book is written in a casual, conversational style, with many real-world examples and anecdotes from the author's experiences. For more information, please visit <https://www.drcloud.com/>.

About the Author



Dr. Henry Cloud is an author, coach, speaker, and clinical psychologist. He has authored 45 books, and coached many leaders, executives and teams on performance, leadership skills and culture. Dr. Cloud founded and built a healthcare company for 10 years, before selling the company and devoting his time to consulting, coaching, speaking, and writing. He holds a BS in psychology with honors from Southern Methodist University, and a PhD in clinical psychology from Biola University.

KEY QUOTES

"At any given moment, you are an amalgam of what has happened up until that moment."